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Hide Tanaka

Hide Tanaka was born in Japan in 1956 and played 70's rock & roll as a guitarist and bassist. His fascination with jazz led him to relocate to New York City in 1982 where he eventually established himself as a versatile acoustic bassist. He is a member of the Junior Mance Trio and appears on a number of recordings, including "Love at Café Loup" and "Out South."

Hide was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 3, 2014 by Monk Rowe, director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in the jazz archive room at Hamilton College, and I'm pleased to have Hide Tanaka here with me today, visiting with Junior Mance. Welcome.

HT: Thank you.

MR: You said the last interview you did was with Russian television?

HT: In Tel Aviv.

MR: In Tel Aviv. How interesting.

HT: Yeah. We had — Junior had a concert last October in Israel. We had like seven concerts.

MR: Well I wanted to start out — I saw something on your website that I thought was well-said. And someone was talking about you and it talked about when you finally got to New York. "He started the jazz life that he had always dreamed of." So you had always dreamed of a jazz life?

HT: Um hum.

MR: From what age did you start to dream of a jazz life?

HT: Sometime from high school, like at 16 years old. Also I started on acoustic bass. Before that I played just rock music, guitar, electric bass. My generation in Japan, mostly, 90 percent of the kids were rock kids. Not jazz at that time.

MR: Not what?

HT: Not jazz.

MR: I'm glad you said that because it's a question I wanted to ask. So you were born in 1956?

HT: '56, yeah.

MR: So we're talking maybe 1970ish?

HT: Yes, seventies.

MR: You were playing rock music?

HT: Yeah, just as a kid. Not with a band, so just myself. Rock, blues.

MR: What were some of the artists that you were playing?

HT: I liked first, B.B. King, the blues. And then, so many rock bands: Led Zeppelin.

MR: Oh, Led Zeppelin?

HT: Yeah Zeppelin and Grand Funk Railroad, Chicago, Blood, Sweat and Tears.

MR: Ooh, my favorite. And how did you hear this music. Did you buy LP's?

HT: Yeah, yeah. Always American was English, the pop charts, just who came through Japan. Actually American hit songs and England, rock hit songs, almost at the same time in Japan they were a big hit too. Yeah.

MR: Did you and your friends speak English at that time?

HT: No. When I came to New York I couldn't speak anything. Couldn't read.

MR: I find it really fascinating that you were listening to American rock & roll sung in English. When you played it, did you sing it in Japanese?

HT: No, no, no, no, just I imitate the guitar. Yeah. I really don't know about the singing.

MR: You were just the guitar player?

HT: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: Were you playing electric bass?

HT: Yeah, sometimes electric bass yeah.

MR: You played rock & roll guitar then.

HT: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: I just find that fascinating how the world is very small now. With music it gets spread around so much.

HT: Right.

MR: If someone came to your country, an American came to your country and wanted to hear traditional Japanese music, what does that consist of?

HT: Oh like Japanese traditional instrumental. The most popular things are a kind of flute, you know, those woodwinds.

MR: Yes, woodwinds.

HT: Like pentatonic.

MR: Yes.

HT: So they cannot play any — like twelve notes. It's possible but very difficult. And three strings instrument, we call it a shamisen. Like I play it like this. And a tsuzumi, like a [scats].

MR: Oh. And taiko drums?

HT: Taiko too. Taiko drums. We don't have much but instrumental.

MR: And does that kind of music get performed in Japan?

HT: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. Actually my mother was a shamisen player.

MR: Oh. How do you spell that?

HT: S-H-A-M-I-S-E-N. Shamisen. It means three taste strings.

MR: Taste.

HT: Three different taste strings.

MR: So you went from rock & roll to jazz music. And how did that happen?

HT: You know, like after I was listening to rock music I was getting tired. It's the same kind of thing. And rock music is more like a performance. Not just practice the instrument. I really wanted to play the instrument, not much like a performer you know, "hi everybody." I'm not that kind of person. So sometimes I went to a Japanese jazz club with my friends, and I was just curious, you know, what is jazz. And the first time I heard acoustic bass I fell in love. I don't know who was playing, I don't care who was playing, I liked this acoustic bass sound. Then just jazz music was at that time — already rock music was using the acoustic bass. And okay, I should play jazz music. I started to get curious, what is jazz music. And after I heard about improvisation, you can change everything you know, and improvise. I really loved the way, how to construct jazz music. And that's why this is my stuff.

MR: How did you go about learning it?

HT: I had a private teacher, a jazz bass player. And he also taught me classical etudes.

MR: Was it something you could get on the radio?

HT: Not on the radio, from the records. I bought a lot of the jazz records and transcribed myself.

MR: Transcribed the bass parts?

HT: Yeah. And sometimes, you know, like any other instrument, for my solo. The solo and bass playing, it's different.

MR: Yes.

HT: Yeah, I transcribed from many bass solos too. But I transcribed guitar players or horn players, a trumpet player.

MR: Is jazz popular in Japan?

HT: Yeah, yeah. I read the history of jazz in Japan. They, in the book, said even before World War I, already Japanese jazz singers existed. And at that time they went to Shanghai. Because Shanghai was a colony of England, or something like that.

MR: Shanghai. Um hum.

HT: Yeah, so there is an English jazz band.

MR: That's right, in fact a fellow named Buck Clayton played in Shanghai like in the 30's. Do you know Eiji Kitamura?

HT: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: He told a very interesting story about some of the musicians heard it over the radio, the United States radio. But the military had their own radio stations and they would hear it from that source.

HT: But my generation is always rock music. Not much jazz.

MR: So you were born ten years after the end of World War II. And is there any, in your experience growing up, what was the memory of World War II. Did it influence your life at all?

HT: No, no. After ten years I mean no more after war era. No more after war era. It's kind of a different generation. I don't have any idea about the war or anything. So Americans means rock star or movie star.

MR: Oh yes, oh, okay.

HT: Not as the enemy or anything.

MR: Right. Okay. But your parents didn't talk about it too much?

HT: My father didn't went to war. He is an instructor for a glider, the airplane, in Japan. And mostly Japanese people knew Japanese Army was crazy. Because nobody thought who had the mind, nobody thought that we were able to win, generally in Japan. But nobody said, because if you said it the military came to you and you'd go to jail.

MR: I see.

HT: So that's why people thought the Army was crazy you know.

MR: They thought the Army was crazy for engaging in such a thing.

HT: Yeah, and such a long time you know.

MR: Wow. Did your parents — what did they think of your fascination with jazz?

HT: My father is a very strict person, you know, very down to earth. And you had to go to the university and find a job. My mother — my father always kind of had the upper hand. So I must follow whatever my father — my mother passed away when I was 17 years old. At that time my father's friend said to him, "let your son do what he wants." Especially this kind of vocation. You know my mother passed away. So then he asked me, "do you have anything to do?" And yea, okay good. Before that I told him I wanted to play music. "What for? How much money you can make? How is the insurance?"

MR: How is the insurance.

HT: No way. But after my mother passed away he kind of softened. And after that everything was fine.

MR: It's interesting, because I almost guessed that he would have got more strict with you.

HT: No.

MR: I'm glad that happened then. So it got to a certain point and you started to think I need to go to the United States?

HT: Because I play any kind of music: Japanese folk music, Japanese kind of rock music, jazz. Even jazz — swing too — free jazz in Japan you know.

MR: Say that again?

HT: Swing jazz to free jazz, avante garde jazz. So I did everything in Japan. Anyway, jazz is American music. And between Japanese people, play with Japanese people and the

audience, everybody is Japanese people, and they said so many great kind of things, and I started thinking, really? Then I thought if I went to New York, and if those great artists said the same things, maybe I agree. But I don't know. But I came to New York totally different. I heard jazz and the high hope of jazz musicians, I saw, in New York. Then I understand what kind of jazz music.

MR: Oh the jazz mission was a theater or something, or maybe I misunderstood you.

HT: No, no, no, no. When I came to New York and I'm listening to real jazz, you know they are great jazz people, and I saw their life, their private life. Then, Japanese musicians are just Japanese music. They play jazz but it's really totally different. You know Japan is Japan of course. It kind of really opened up.

MR: Did you have money saved up when you came here, to try to —

HT: I really couldn't bear it in Japan because sometimes I was just so frustrated. People were saying so much things about jazz music. I couldn't get it. So I sometimes kind of snapped. I wanted to go to New York. And I sold everything. And even I couldn't speak English or even read anything. But I did want to go to New York.

MR: Do you mind telling that green card story again? Because I found that fascinating.

HT: So therefore I didn't have any money or anything. I just came to United States as a tourist. A three month visa.

MR: Oh, a three month visa.

HT: Yeah. I thought I don't have money, and I don't have much time to earn money, because I wanted to really study jazz music. So I will just overstay. And I couldn't get out, because therefore I couldn't get out from the United States because I am overstaying. Nine years I did overstay. I just came as a tourist.

MR: You stayed nine years?

HT: Yeah.

MR: Does that mean that they were looking for you?

HT: No.

MR: The Immigration Service.

HT: No at that time there were so many of that kind of people. So therefore they started to issue green cards for those unknown people. Because they really wanted people to live in the United States. So this was a lottery. A green card. But at first they started to do that lottery — people were really afraid. This is a kind of scheme for overstaying people, so people didn't apply. But then they officially announced this is not any snare or scheme. Even they don't care how many years you are overstaying. They didn't say it officially, but people understood, don't worry about it. So I sent a mail, an application, and I got a green card from Japan.

MR: But you had to prove that you —

HT: Yeah. They said — they didn't say anything about you must prove or anything in the document. It was a lottery. No matter what, as long as you were not a criminal. So I thought oh, we got a lottery. And an American officer in the Japanese-American Embassy, they knew I was nine years overstaying. And they are not happy about that. I think maybe so, that's the reason. Suddenly they said "you must prove your profession. You said you are a musician. How do we know you are a musician?" And I kind of panicked. In the document there is no part that I must prove my professionality. But how? Anyway if you couldn't prove your professionality, then they shut the door. And I panicked.

MR: You panicked, yeah.

HT: And I asked so many people, and so many American people were kind of laughing. They know what happens even inside the embassy, the American Embassy people were kind of laughing. And some guy just came out and he didn't even see me but he just "don't give up, don't give up. Anyway, you can do it yourself, just try it." Anyway I came back to my hotel and I started calling the people and "can you borrow me the bass, just one day?" "No way." And the next day I went back to the American Embassy with a bass. But even security did not say yes. They said "what, this is the American Embassy. What are you doing with this big thing?" But I still remember the name of Kim. And my officer, she said I have to prove my occupation. This is just the only way I am able to prove. So the security guy went inside of the building and called the police in Japanese and the police came back and said "oh I really don't know how the Americans are thinking." Anyway "I'm sorry, sir, you can come in with that." And I got inside and I had an interview. And I brought the bass with the glass window.

MR: The glass window, yeah.

HT: And he said, "okay, show me." And the funny thing, inside, some officer brought a guitar. And she said "we have a musician too. So you must play with our musician." Because he was an officer you know. So anyway he started tuning. Very out of tune. And "hey wait, I'm with you tuning up. I cannot play with you." And he started playing, kind of red faced. "Oh really?"

MR: Oh you mean he's got the toot-toot, the tuning whistle.

HT: And still, "your tuning is terrible."

MR: You're lucky they didn't boot you out of the country.

HT: And after that, I said "I want to play 'Saints Go Marching In' key of D." And also he sung. And there's a window. He's inside. I'm outside. And everybody's waiting, what the hell is going on. And the Navy's people come in and they started clapping. Oh man that sounds good. And I finished. And he said "can we play one more? 'You Are My Sunshine.' Also key of D."

MR: Of course.

HT: And he sang. And after that my officer came and said "we'll have a party later tonight." It's a kind of joke. I said yes but I'm very expensive. And he was laughing. Then, after that, he gave me the green card.

MR: That is a great story. That's called paying dues. How did you make, when you were here those nine years, you had a day job or were you playing also?

HT: Yeah, I had a day job, a dishwasher or getting ready for the lunchbox. And I played the street too.

MR: You played the street.

HT: And I had many roommates.

MR: You had a tough incident when you first arrived.

HT: Yeah. The second month.

MR: The second month.

HT: After a jam session, and I just bought a hamburger at Burger King and was walking. The first five months I was living at a hotel near Times Square. And some guy with two girls was screaming at me and dragged me around and threw me. And I had three stitches.

MR: He threw you through a window?

HT: Yeah. Three stitches. And no reason. He didn't pick up my wallet or my wrist watch. Maybe he thought I was somebody he knew that he didn't like. I don't know. And the police came. But the good news is within three months, still I am a tourist. So they were very aware and they brought me to a hospital and did surgery, everything for free.

MR: Because you were a tourist.

HT: Yeah, yeah. Just the second month.

MR: I didn't realize they had that kind of treatment for tourists. That's nice. How did you get hooked up with Junior Mance?

HT: I had a gig, Jazz At Noon it's called. Anyway, they had every Friday at 2 p.m., every Friday they had a guest also. Just famous people. Junior Mance and so many. I think they had Tommy Flanagan, he was one of the guests. And he used to bring his own bass. But at that time the bass player couldn't make it, so I started to play with him. The first time I played with him it kind of clicked. And already I was living in New York over twenty years. But I never spoke with Junior, and Junior asked me, "how long you have been here?" And I said "over twenty years." And Junior says "why don't you call me?" He was joking, you know. Then after that, soon, like two days after, he called me and had a gig at Knickerbocker. That's when it just happened. And I played Knickerbocker and after we played two days he asked me to be the regular bass player.

MR: Nice. Well someone asked last night, a student sort of asked a question about why are some musicians really compatible from the start almost. Can you answer that? Why a bass player and a piano player can really work together right from the beginning.

HT: After eight years, I use like a karma. I don't know why. Sometimes two musicians love the same kind of music and when they started they are both great musicians. But those two people never happen. Sometimes those things happen. But sometimes really great musicians, even if they play different kinds of music normally, but sometimes two musicians start to play, sometimes great things will happen. It's kind of a mystery. It's the same like general relationships too. Sports sometimes too. Those who start to play altogether not necessarily become a good team. Big ego. Too much big ego. And their own style.

MR: That is a great analogy. When you think about the great people, Cannonball Adderley and Miles Davis, and those fellas didn't play together that long because they were destined to be their own leaders. And yesterday when we were talking to a couple of the students about bass solos, I think you had something interesting to say about bass solos. What do you feel about —

HT: Yeah, the bass player — the most important thing is to play bass of course. But okay one of the reasons I really wanted to play bass is I really love the sound. But also at that time, the seventies, there were so many super bass players that came out. Stanley Clarke, Miroslav Vitous, Neils Henning, Jordan [inaudible], Eddie Gomez. So all those players became famous means they began to play in the up high register. So people understand what they're playing. All the best players playing solos in the low register people don't know, okay this is a bass solo but just sounds [scats]. But when they started an octave higher, like a cello register while they're playing bass, in the higher register, people really knew the melody what the bass player was playing. Instead of [scats].

MR: They couldn't distinguish the difference if they stayed down low.

HT: Yeah most people. And that's why, especially now, great pick-ups we are able to use. So people can hear very well what the bass player is playing. And also everybody mostly when their solo started people started talking. [scats] So if you play a more distinct sound with the bass people still concentrate to the band the same.

MR: I see.

HT: It's not time to go to the rest room.

MR: Yeah there's actually a couple of jokes about that. How to get people to talk? Take a bass solo. That's very neat. I noticed last night when you were playing that when it was time for your solo that you did something different to stand out. Whether it was with a bow or going up high.

HT: Actually this trio is kind of different. And Junior really wanted to play talking together sometimes. Not this is a piano solo. Not this is a bass solo. But he wanted to play sometimes all together. Sometimes speak all together. You know he plays something, even if this is his solo, but I play something — that's why he made this trio. So he said this was the first experience of this kind. It's just happened after he started hiring me and we kind of developed a duo, just a duo, minus the drums, just a duo. Duo music is different from trio music. So he kind of started an intimate way of creating music. And his student, Michi, anyway, always sometime he wanted to use a violin player. And mostly classical training. The violin player cannot play in any key sometimes. But she is more flexible. So that's the history of how that happened.

MR: I wanted to play a brief piece of music for you, to see what you think of it:
[musical interlude]

HT: Oh, this is — he's a good photographer too. Yes, slap bass. Milt Hinton.

MR: To me the bass player, when you don't have a drummer, the bass player becomes the drummer too. Did you ever get to meet Milt Hinton?

HT: No. When I came in the eighties he was still around. But in the eighties I was kind of more like a new kind of jazz. I started appreciating this kind of style more after I was over 40. So now I am 55, and like 15 years ago I started listening to really old style of jazz. Because my generation was into fusion.

MR: Fusion. Yes.

HT: And already Miles Davis was kind of classic for me. So I didn't dig it, any so-called bebop. For me it's really boring music.

MR: Really.

HT: Because in Japan I was listening to bebop records, just old recordings, just two minutes or three minutes, and maybe a good line, but no bass solo, no drum solo. But I didn't know that it was because of the limitations of the recording. But I thought that was bebop. So that's why I came to New York, '82, and I heard for the first time Barry Harris. Now he played like a five minute, ten minute solo, and go to the drum solo, bass solo, and interplay with each other. Oh. Wow. This is what I played with the fusion, more interplay than straight jazz. And I was kind of surprised. You know? I heard Barry Harris in person and the old bebop players. Oh. This is jazz. And because of the recordings at that time, my age, musicians of my age who played bebop, everybody played two or three minutes, every song, just as they transcribed from the records. Kind of really boring, that kind of music, for me. So I didn't know really how to do straight jazz in combination with the musicians, joking, the whole thing. Like the old records for me were a kind of archive. They were good bebop lines, but not for me alive. It was like a long time ago people played this kind of music.

MR: Right. Because that music was about — well it was only about twenty years old — well no, more like thirty I guess in 1980. Bebop being the late '40's and early '50's. Yeah. But that's really interesting about the recording technology and how it limited the players.

HT: Because American people, they knew this music because they went to the live music jazz clubs, the bebop. But Japanese jazz musicians, they really don't know, just from the record. Two minutes. So everybody played it like that way.

MR: That's a really interesting outlook. What's a typical week like for you?

HT: Week?

MR: I mean like, being a working musician, what do you do during a particular week? Do you do a lot of different things?

HT: Yeah. A lot of different things. I cannot say this week or that week or this month or that month. Every year, every time it's different. I cannot predict anything.

MR: So what do you do besides play with Junior?

HT: I play with other people. Every Tuesday I have a jam session, a house band. I don't teach. I just play.

MR: You're just a player. Is it — I don't know how to ask this — is it an easy life?

HT: For me. For me it's easy. Because I don't have any choice. I really wanted to live this way. And I went to school in Japan too, but I really wanted to play, just play. I'm not a good teacher so — because if you know this way, then it's so many things, financial you know. Yes of course I am sometimes scared of financial things, but now I am 58 years. There's always something bad happening. Then next time something's happening. Like okay. After nine years I'm an illegal alien, and nine years I'm just playing in the street, and you know, I started thinking of going back to Japan because I didn't have any career, just playing on the street. Then I got the green card. So that means, you must stay. Okay, okay. And after I got the green card I married. I divorced already. But I had a good 17 years. It's always something.

MR: It sounds like your karma.

HT: Yeah, yeah, yeah. I think so.

MR: And are you a citizen now?

HT: No. But I have a green card.

MR: Okay. So you can stay here.

HT: Yeah, Whatever I want, yeah.

MR: Yeah. Wow. Do you have any other goals? I mean do you have a goal of leading your own band?

HT: Yeah, I think in jazz life, they don't have any goals. Like every day is important. Like classical — I have a concert for the Beethoven, that is one of the goals. You know, right? And becoming professor at some university. But jazz life every day is kind of new things.

Sometimes unexpected things happen on the bandstand. Like Junior yesterday suddenly started to play in a different key.

MR: Yes.

HT: And all these young people, the parents always ask me the question, you know my son or my daughter studies jazz music and now, how many years until she is able to get somewhere, or does she have any goal. And all the time I tell those parents there are no goals with jazz musicians. There are no goals, like you said, having a concert. Because you can do, having the concert, but the jazz music is not able to do music for the concert. Because every day you play somewhere, and that's most important. Every day it's music, until the last moment.

MR: I appreciate your saying that. It makes sense. I mean look at Junior Mance. He's been playing since the mid-40's and he's still doing it, and he acts like what's happening tonight is my goal.

HT: And so therefore even when he started playing the music for sound check, already he is really — meaning no sound check music. Sometimes people ask him to stop.

MR: Right I know what you mean.

HT: And the way he casually starts some songs, like yesterday, the same song with a different key, when he started he cannot stop until he finishes. But that is really just a jazz musician's life. When you start music, that is the goal. So when you start the music the goal is until it's finished, that song. That is the goal. How you are able to create good music just now. I really love that spirit. Not something in the future I'll be able to do this concerto. No, no, no, no.

MR: Who are your three favorite bass players?

HT: Ray Brown, Sam Jones, Paul Chambers. I love their rhythm.

MR: Yes. I can tell. A bass player I think has to have a certain — they have to have their ego in place. I mean that's my sense of it. You have to be happy providing — as Milt Hinton called it, "providing a rhythmic service" and then you'll have your moments in the spotlight too.

HT: Yeah. The rhythm is the most important for a jazz bass player.

MR: Right. Well this has been a fascinating conversation. I want to thank you for joining me. Oh, your story about being covered with snow walking — what part of the city were you in?

HT: Midtown. Times Square.

MR: Why won't a cab driver pick up a bass player on those kinds of nights?

HT: Because they are busy with just ordinary people. Why — they are so much busy, and to stop for the bass player with a soaked up bass and snow and everything inside the car. They don't want to bother.

MR: How many blocks did you have to walk that night?

HT: 40 minute walk.

MR: 40 minutes. Covered with snow. Again, paying dues, right? Well thanks for your time today. I look forward to your concert tonight.

HT: All right.